



Review

Reviewed Work(s): *An Introduction to the Philosophy of Bernard Lonergan* by Hugo A. Meynell

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AN INTRODUCTION TO THE PHILOSOPHY OF BERNARD LONERGAN. By HUGO A. MEYNELL. New York, Barnes & Noble, 1976. Pp. ix, 201. \$25.00.

"In my own opinion, *Insight* [Lonergan's major philosophical work] . . . is at a conservative estimate one of the half-dozen or so most important philosophical books to have appeared in the course of the present century" (p. 1). So Meynell introduces his subject, and then turns immediately to the task at which, I think, he is largely successful—of giving us some sense of the range and system and quality of thought which could lead someone—and have led others besides Mr. Meynell—to make that sort of judgment on the work of this as yet little known philosopher.

'Thoroughly understand what it is to understand, and not only will you understand the broad lines of all there is to be understood, but also you will possess a fixed base, an invariant pattern, opening upon all further developments of understanding.' [*Insight* (London, 1957), xxviii.] . . . The hint from which the argument of the book originates, that study of the human understanding is the way to determine the fundamental nature of the world revealed to that understanding, is of course the starting-point of the classical British empiricists Locke, Berkeley [sic],¹ and Hume; but the metaphysical consequences of the method as pursued by Lonergan are not, to say the least of it, the same as those arrived at by the empiricists [p. 1].

At the heart of Lonergan's theory of knowledge is the notion of "insight," "the mental act by which [diverse scraps of information] are grasped as cohering in an orderly and intelligible whole" (p. 2). Typically, insight (which Lonergan also calls the "act of understanding") is into the data of experience as known through the senses. (It can also be into the images of sensory imagination.) In these concrete presentations it grasps an abstract intelligible pattern. Formulated in concepts, an insight is an answer to a question of the general type "What is this?" or "Why does it happen?" All the questions we can ask can be divided into two basic kinds, that just mentioned, the questions for intelligence, and, secondly, the questions for reflection, of the form "Does that exist?" "Is that so?", in which we ask "whether the theory we have arrived at [by insight] is so or is not so, whether

¹ It is unfortunately necessary to note how poorly those responsible for the proofreading of the book have done their job: more than 25 printing errors in 210 pages force themselves on the reader's attention. This is, of course, especially a pity when it happens in a good book like this one.

the kind of thing that we have postulated exists or does not exist . . . ” (p. 7). The question for reflection is answered by a judgment, a “Yes” or “No,” which is grasped as “virtually unconditioned,” that is, as having its conditions fulfilled, and so is affirmed. This three-fold dynamic pattern of experience, understanding and judgment is, according to Lonergan, the basic structure of all cognitional process. It is initiated and carried through by the “pure desire to know,” and its objective, to be reached at the final stage of judgment, is knowledge of the real, of what is, of “being.” And that objective, Lonergan argues, it is successful in achieving:

Since Hume and Kant it has been very usual among philosophers to attribute the intelligible order which we seem to find in the universe simply to the activity of the human mind, and to deny that it can be rightly inferred to exist in reality itself prior to the imposition of a conceptual framework by the human mind in the process of understanding it. But according to Lonergan . . . both the phenomena which we experience and the intelligible pattern within which they are found to cohere are aspects of the real objective world which confronts the human inquirer [p. 2].

Such is the bare outline of Lonergan’s analysis of human understanding. Through an excellent summary of the long and difficult argument of *Insight*, Meynell allows us to watch Lonergan introduce, illustrate, and greatly elaborate his analysis through a study of cognitional process in the mathematician, the empirical scientist (primarily the physicist), and the man of common sense, then argue that cognitional process in fact achieves objective knowledge of the real. We see Lonergan draw out the metaphysical consequences (for, to the basic operations and methods of the process of knowing there correspond fundamental features of the thing that is known, and, since cognitional process does actually achieve objective knowledge of the real, these features must be affirmed as fundamental aspects of being), then illustrate and apply his main theses in a strikingly wide range of fields, including in addition to those mentioned depth psychology, social theory, hermeneutics, ethics, and natural theology. What emerges, of course, is a form of Aristotelianism, but an Aristotelianism, in answer to our needs at least since Descartes, turned inside out by having its cognitional theory made to ground an epistemology which is prior to and the foundation of its metaphysics, and purged of “Greek science and medieval common sense” (p. 67). This last result, incidentally, is achieved in part by the development and application of a philosophy of contemporary science, which is certainly not the least attractive part of Lonergan’s work, and which ought to be of interest in itself to students of that subject.

To this writer, Meynell's introduction could have been improved chiefly by the incorporation of a more critical element. As it stands, the book is largely a synopsis of Lonergan's *Insight*. It is very good synopsis—accurate, concise, admirably successful in disengaging the main lines of the argument from Lonergan's difficult style and from the technically demanding illustrations from mathematics and physics in the earlier chapters, yet conveying something of the scope and fullness of Lonergan's thought. But one would have liked to see Meynell deal more fully and critically with the kinds of questions that are likely to be raised about Lonergan's work, especially by analytic philosophers (since it is towards them, primarily, that Meynell has directed his introduction). To mention only two questions, but questions which go to the heart of Lonergan's enterprise: Is there any mental *act* of understanding? And is the kind of appeal to introspection which Lonergan appears to make at crucial points of his argument valid? Meynell does indeed provide us with a concluding chapter on "Lonergan and the Problems of Contemporary [namely, Analytic] Philosophy." This is a useful brief placing of Lonergan's view in the context of other main views in the analytic tradition on the topics of theory of science, epistemology and metaphysics, moral philosophy, and philosophy of religion. (For this sort of "placing" the footnotes throughout the book are also important.) Certainly the categories here are broad enough; but I think the book would have been strengthened by the treatment of a fuller selection of problems under these and some other headings, and by more of that wrestling with Lonergan's thought which seems really to get under way only in the section on philosophy of religion.

Still, this is perhaps not so much a criticism of the present book, as a wish that Meynell might someday write another one. What he has given us now is an excellent overview of main lines of Lonergan's philosophical thought. Those who suspect that Lonergan is indeed a thinker who deserves to be far better known than he is will welcome Meynell's book and hope that it is widely read.

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